



Geoff Crammond's Grand Prix 4

Welcome to race day

Grand Prix 4 aims at putting you on the F1 arena once again. Like its predecessors, the game offers vivid array of cars and original locales to race in. Good graphics and sound make the whole package quite interesting. Options, such as the standard Quick race, Non-championship race and Full championship, are included. But what's really worth checking out is the Quick Laps option. This mode lets up to 22 drivers take each other on for the fastest qualifying time.

The graphics are sensational, with very realistic effects—you can almost feel the water drops hitting the screen, and the debris that falls when the cars crash is also very realistic. It also sports true racing sounds—you can hear the mud churn when you miss bends, and the water pelt- ing against your screen.



The AI can be pretty dumb or really cool at times. If you move outside the racing lines, the other cars just stay behind you instead of seizing the opportunity to overtake; At other times the cars will do almost anything to block your path. You

can also opt for AI assists to drive your car, though with all assists on, it is actually an effort to try and crash your car. Although, racing junkies will find these assists tiresome, newbies will probably welcome them.

The replays are awesome, with perfect camera angles and placement. Watch cars overtake opponents and whiz by you. Even the pit crew are rendered in full 3D, and a sight to see when they are in full flow. The wheel controller does add to the realism, though the one we tested with didn't work well with this game.

The game is buggy, and crashes without rhyme or reason. It can be exasperating, especially if you are about to make Montoya eat your dust, and end up staring at the drab Windows desktop. Apart from this, it is a super gaming experience.

Genre: Sports simulation ■ **Developer:** Micro Prose ■ **Distributor:** Milestone Interactive Software Ltd ■ **Phone:** 022-28381614 ■ **Website:** www.grandprixgames.com ■ **Price:** Rs 699 ■ **System Requirements:** 400 MHz, 64MB RAM, 16MB DirectX 8.1compatible video Card ■ **Rating:** ★★★★★



Labyrinth's Briefcase Microsoft Word and Excel 2002

Briefcase education

This series of books is designed as courseware for the Microsoft Office User Specialist certification program. Both the Word and Excel books that we reviewed are Level 1 beginner books, but the series goes up to Level 3. With nearly 230 pages starting from absolute basic concepts, usage and practical examples, these books are designed to bring you up to speed with the rest of the Office-literate world.

The course is divided into seven chapters, each based on a case study used to illustrate the various commands and features explained in that chapter. A chapter introduces the example scenario, and the tasks to be performed to achieve the goal. Then it begins a series of Concept Overviews followed by a hands-on to practice usage of the concept. The concepts are brief and clearly illustrated, with screenshots where appropriate. Each

concept only deals with one small feature, making it short and easy to follow. The immediate follow up with a step-by-step illustrated hands-on is very useful to reinforce the new concept.

All chapters end with a series of revision sections. A simple multiple choice Concepts Review helps you identify what you forgot. A series of Skill Builders provide further practical exercise. Introducing multiple small, manageable chunks of new information followed up by immediate practical application is an effective technique for learning new concepts.

There is a liberal sprinkling of Quick Reference spots throughout the book that



help highlight special interface features such as the Tab and Indent markers on the ruler or procedures such as changing the page orientation. The overall impression is that of a well thought out course presented in an easily understood and practical manner.

As a Level 1 book, the authors are quite considerate of the fact that new computer users may not be very comfortable with using menus and icons, and attempt to show rather than tell everywhere possible. The information presentation is in a refreshingly visual, easy to understand style.

If you are looking at alternatives to signing up for a computer class to get started with Microsoft Office, put *Labyrinth's Briefcase* series on your shopping checklist.

Publisher: Shroff Publishers and Distributors Pvt Ltd ■ **Author:** Brian Favro and Russel Stolins ■ **Distributor:** Computer Bookshop Pvt Ltd ■ **Phone:** 022-2317922/ 23/ 24 ■ **Fax:** 022-2623551 ■ **E-mail:** orders@cb-india.com ■ **Web site:** www.cb-india.com ■ **Price:** Rs 250 (each) ■ **Rating:** ★★★★★